FREE BOOK

Introduction to Consent

Consent for everyday life first: hugs, high-fives, borrowed things, photos and saying no. Then what it means in relationships.

WHO IT IS FOR
Autistic children, young people and adults, with the parents, carers, teachers and SNAs who support them.

NCCA STAGE
Primary · Junior Cycle · Senior Cycle and LCA · Adults

Easy read

Consent means I say yes, or no, or not sure. I choose. I can change my mind at any time.

How to use this resource

- Start with Part 1 (everyday consent) with every reader. It is the foundation for everything else.
- Practise the yes, no and not sure scripts out loud. Practise until they feel easy.
- Use the scenario cards on pages 6 and 7. Cut them out, read one, and decide: yes, no or ask.
- Part 3 is for older readers (Senior Cycle, LCA and adults). Adults should read it first and decide what is right for the reader.

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Version 1.0 · introduction-to-consent

Part 1: What is consent?

Consent means saying **yes** to something, and meaning it. It is about my body, my things and my choices. Everyone has the right to feel safe, and everyone has the right to choose.



Consent means I choose.



I can say yes.



I can say no.



I can say 'I am not sure.' That means wait.



I can change my mind at any time.



I never have to say yes to stay safe, to be kind or to keep a friend.

Three rules of consent

1. **Freely given.** I say yes because I want to. Nobody forces me, tricks me or pressures me. Nobody makes me feel I must say yes.
2. **Can be changed at any time.** Yes today can be no tomorrow. Yes a minute ago can be no now. I can stop whenever I want.
3. **Asked clearly.** The other person asks me, in words I understand. I can answer in words, in pictures, or with a card. If I do not answer, that is not a yes.

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Everyday consent

Consent is not only about bodies. We use it every day. These are good places to practise.



Hugs

Ask first: 'Can I give you a hug?' You can say no thanks.

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High-fives

Ask first: 'High five?' A wave or a nod is fine instead.

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Borrowing things

Ask first: 'Can I borrow your pencil?' Wait for the answer.

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Photos

Ask first: 'Can I take your photo?' Ask again before you share it.

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Saying no

'No thanks.' It is OK to say no, even to someone you like.

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Joining in

Ask: 'Can I play?' Listen to the answer. A no is a no.

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Ask first. Wait for the answer.



If the answer is no, I stop.



Thank the person for telling me. No is OK.

Notes for adults

- Do not make a child hug, kiss or sit on someone's knee, including relatives. Offer a choice: a wave, a high-five, a fist bump, or nothing. This teaches that their body belongs to them.
- When your child says no to you, respect it where you safely can, and thank them for telling you. They learn that no gets heard.
- Many autistic children and adults find eye contact, touch and unexpected contact uncomfortable. A no is communication, not rudeness.
- Some people say yes when they mean no, because they want to please or do not know they can refuse. Teach no, stop and not sure equally, and give non-verbal options.

Part 2: Yes, no and not sure

Say these out loud. Practise with an adult or a friend. Choose the words that feel right and change them to suit you.

Yes

- 'Yes, please.'
- 'Yes, a high-five is good.'
- 'Yes, I would like that.'

No

- 'No, thanks.'
- 'Stop. I do not like that.'
- 'No. I am going now.'

Not sure

- 'I am not sure. Wait.'
- 'Can I think about it?'
- 'I will ask someone first.'

I do not have to give a reason.

A person who respects me hears no and stops.

If they do not stop, I say it again, and I tell a trusted adult.

What if I cannot say it?

Some people cannot speak when they are stressed, or they speak in a different way. That is OK. Choose other ways to say no, and share them with the people around you:

- A red card or a stop card held up.
- A pointing card, a wristband or a sign.
- Walking away to a safe adult.
- Typing, a talker device or a phone message.

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How my body tells me: 'I do not want this'

Our bodies send signals when something is not OK. Some autistic people notice these signals late, or in a different way. That is fine. We can learn to notice them. Here are some common signals. Yours may be different.



Worried feeling

A tight tummy, or butterflies that do not feel nice.

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Breathing changes

Fast breathing, or holding my breath.

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Heart beats fast

My heart is racing. I feel hot or shaky.

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Feel sad or flat

I want to cry, or I feel numb.

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Want to leave

I want to run away, hide or go quiet.

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Feel cross

My face is hot. I want to shout or push away.

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My own body signals

When I do not want something, my body feels: _____

A signal I notice first: _____

What I can do when I feel it: _____

A grown-up I can tell: _____



When I notice the signal, I stop and check.



I can say stop. I can walk away.



I can tell a trusted adult.

Practice scenarios: yes, no or ask?

Cut out the cards. Read one. Decide: **yes** (green), **no** (red) or **ask** (amber). Then check the answers in the adult notes on the next page.



A friend asks, 'Can I hug you?' You want a hug.

What do you say?

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A friend asks, 'Can I hug you?' You do not want one.

What do you say?

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You want to borrow a classmate's pencil case.

What do you do?

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Someone takes your photo without asking.

What do you do?

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A teacher puts out a hand for a high-five. You are not sure.

What do you do?

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Someone you like says, 'Do you want to hold hands?'

What do you do if you are not sure?

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More scenarios



A friend wants to post your photo online.

What do you say?

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Someone says, 'If you are my friend you will say yes.'

What do you do?

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You said no, and the person keeps asking.

What do you do?

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You said yes to a game. Now you want to stop.

What do you do?

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Someone says, 'Do not tell anyone.'

What do you do?

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You are not sure if something is OK.

What do you do?

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Notes for adults: answers to the scenarios

- **Hug, wanted:** YES. 'Yes please.' **Hug, not wanted:** NO. 'No thanks. High-five?' **Pencil case:** ASK first, wait for yes. **Photo without asking:** NO. 'Please delete it.' Tell an adult if they will not. **Teacher high-five, not sure:** ASK. 'Not now, thanks.' A wave is fine.
- **Hold hands, not sure:** ASK for time. 'I am not sure. Can I think?' Not sure means wait. **Post photo online:** NO unless you agree. 'Please do not post it.' **'You will say yes if you are my friend':** NO. A real friend accepts no. Tell a trusted adult.
- **Keeps asking:** NO again, then leave and tell an adult. **Change mind in a game:** YES to stopping. 'I want to stop now.' **'Do not tell anyone':** a secret that makes you feel worried is not OK to keep. Tell a trusted adult. **Not sure:** ASK or wait.
- Praise any answer that keeps the child safe, and talk through what they might say in their own words.

Part 3: Consent in relationships (older readers)

For adults first

This section is for Senior Cycle and LCA students and adults. It is factual and plain. Read it first and decide with the young person what is right for them. It covers sexual consent. Young people may also choose to read it with a trusted person. Many autistic young people say that clear, literal rules help them most.



Consent matters in every relationship.



Both people say a clear yes, with words, every time.



Consent can be changed or taken back at any time.



Consent is freely given. No pressure, no tricks, no threats.



No answer, silence or freezing is not a yes.



If someone is very drunk, high, asleep or unwell, they cannot consent.

What the law in Ireland says

In Ireland, the **legal age of consent to sexual activity is 17**. Below that age, a person cannot legally agree to sexual activity. Consent also has to be freely given at any age. Without consent, sexual activity is a crime, whatever the age.

Sharing an intimate image of someone without their consent, or threatening to, is a crime in Ireland under Coco's Law (2020). Making, having or sharing a sexual image of anyone under 18 is also serious in law, even if it is an image of yourself. If this happens, tell a trusted adult. Do not forward the image. You can report images at hotline.ie.

Checking in

In a relationship, checking in is a kind and clear thing to do. Here are some examples. Use your own words.

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Asking

'Would you like to kiss?' or 'Is this OK?'

Checking while it is happening

'Are you still OK with this?'

Saying no

'No, I do not want to. Please stop.'

Not sure

'I am not sure. Can we stop for now?'

Hearing no

'OK. Thanks for telling me.' Then stop. Do not ask again and again.

Changing your mind

'I said yes before. I have changed my mind. Please stop.'

Remember

- A partner or someone you like does not get to decide for you.
- Having said yes before does not mean yes now. Being in a relationship does not mean yes.
- A person who loves you, or likes you, accepts your no.
- If you are not sure about a relationship or something that happened, talk to a trusted adult, the GP, or a helpline. Not everyone feels able to say the words in the moment, and that is never your fault.

If something happened that was not OK

It is never your fault. You can tell a trusted adult, your GP, Gardaí or the Dublin Rape Crisis Centre helpline (1800 77 88 88, free, 24 hours). Under 18: Childline 1800 66 66 66 or text 50101. You can also text HELLO to 50808.

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For adults: supporting consent every day

- **Model it.** Ask before you hug, help with dressing, or touch. 'Can I help with your coat?'
- **Offer choices.** Give a way to say yes, no or not sure without words if needed.
- **Respect no.** When a child says no, stop where you safely can. Say 'thank you for telling me.'
- **Teach the body signals.** Name feelings and body clues. Use pictures.
- **Teach with the whole community.** Use the same words at home, school and in respite or residential care.
- **Cover care.** Explain intimate care in advance. Say what will happen, who will help, and that they can say stop.
- **Be aware of power.** Autistic people are more likely to be told what to do. Check that a yes is a real yes, not compliance.
- **Teach the law early enough.** Older students need clear facts about the age of consent and about images online.

Notes for adults: when a young person tells you something

- Stay calm. Listen. Believe them. Thank them for telling you.
- Do not promise to keep it secret. Say you will need to tell someone whose job it is to keep them safe.
- In school, tell the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) the same day. Otherwise contact Tusla. Follow Children First (2017) and the Child Protection Procedures for Schools (2023).
- Do not ask leading questions or investigate yourself.

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strands **Myself** and **Myself and Others**, strand units *Safety and protection* and *My friends and other people*; Stay Safe programme.
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 3 **Relationships and Sexuality**, and Strand 1 **Understanding Myself and Others**.
- NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs; Children First (2017) and Child Protection Procedures for Schools (2023).

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Emergency

112 or 999 — Gardaí, ambulance or fire. Use it if someone is in danger now.

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Rape Crisis Help

Dublin Rape Crisis Centre national helpline, free and 24 hours: 1800 77 88 88.

Hotline.ie

Report intimate images shared without consent, and child sexual abuse material, at hotline.ie. They can help get images removed.

HSE Sexual Wellbeing

Free information, free STI testing and free contraception information at sexualwellbeing.ie.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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